

The EU's other top diplomat

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC GO

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GOOD MORNING. This is Sebastian Starcevic, POLITICO's designated survivor in Brussels.

In today's Playbook:

- Dubravka Šuica on Ceuta, Israel and Trump's Board of Peace.
- A key S&D lawmaker defends his group's China approach.
- Faces in the crowd: Jared Kushner, Ursula von der Leyen, Kaja Kallas, Pavlo Palisa, Josep Borrell, Donald Trump, Gideon Sa'ar, Javi López, Keir Starmer, Wang Yi, Bashar Assad and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian hash out why Europe is finding it so hard to wean itself off U.S. data-crunching behemoth Palantir.

DRIVING THE DAY

THE EU'S OTHER TOP DIPLOMAT: A migration crisis on Spanish territory and wars in the Middle East have given the EU's Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica one of the toughest briefs of any member of the bloc's executive — and transformed her into a key lieutenant of Commission President Ursula von der Leyen.

"No one could have predicted how quickly events unfolded since the start of the mandate," the Croatian commissioner told Playbook in an interview on a windy morning from her hometown of Dubrovnik. "[Bashar] Assad was still there in Syria. There was no war between Lebanon and Israel." And now, it's the crisis in the Spanish enclave of Ceuta, which has left around 75 people dead and sent shock waves through the EU.

Still friends: EU and Morocco remain strong partners, Šuica said — despite the events of the past few days. One incident shouldn't define the relationship, she said, adding that the EU cooperated with Tunisia to curb illegal migration by about 80 percent and should follow that model with Rabat.

Battlefields, not beaches: The gig as Mediterranean commissioner sounded uncontroversial when it was first announced, conjuring up images of island-hopping diplomacy and trips to Europe's sunniest capitals. But it has turned into a geopolitically heavy portfolio, with Šuica becoming von der Leyen's go-to emissary on high-profile missions, from Washington to Tel Aviv.

Mending fences: Šuica was dispatched to Israel in June to meet with Foreign Minister Gideon Sa'ar, just as Sa'ar was engaged in a bitter dispute with the EU's top diplomat Kaja Kallas over reports she had likened Israel's treatment of Palestinians to apartheid. Kallas' predecessor Josep Borrell accused the Commission and Šuica of lacking solidarity with Kallas by not canceling the trip and the visit fed into a broader institutional clash between the Commission and the EU's diplomatic service.

Big picture: "Without Israel, you can't do anything," Šuica said, referring to the need to get aid into Gaza. "We need the approval of Israeli authorities. And this is why we have to keep channels open ... They are there and we need to work with them." Her Middle East missions are all coordinated "around a table" with Kallas and other commissioners, she pointed out.

Trump gamble: Šuica also jetted off to Washington in February to attend a meeting of U.S. President Donald Trump's controversial Board of Peace. Her presence as an observer — at von der Leyen's request — ruffled feathers in Brussels and other capitals, which felt the EU shouldn't give legitimacy to Trump's initiative.

Worth it: Šuica admitted that hearing the criticism wasn't easy for her, but insisted the trip was a "good move from our side" because it led to Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner attending the EU's Palestine Donor Group aid conference last month. "The Americans came, they wanted to coordinate with us," she said, adding that helping Gaza was the only goal.

Pragmatic diplomacy: Šuica is a former mayor of Dubrovnik, which managed to remain an independent republic for centuries, despite being surrounded by powerful empires. She mused that the city's history of shrewd diplomacy runs in her blood, arguing the EU needs to be similarly pragmatic on the world stage.

For example: EU members are right to be outraged by the deaths of thousands of Palestinians, she said. "What happened in Gaza, of course, nobody can justify this." But she urged the bloc, which is deadlocked on suspending its association agreement with Israel, "to be calm" and avoid moves that could be politicized in Israel's election in October. "It's not our role to interfere in their elections."

NOW READ: Last week's surge of tens of thousands of migrants into Ceuta has thrown Madrid onto the defensive over Morocco's long-standing claim to its exclaves, Aitor Hernández-Morales explains.

BIG AND BREAKING

AI TARGETS CODERS: Anthropic and OpenAI models created fake online personas and tried to deceive human coders to launch cyberattacks during a safety evaluation, the U.K.'s AI Security Institute has disclosed .

IN THE MIDDLE EAST: The U.S., Iran and Oman are closing in on an interim agreement to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, with Washington hoping to announce it today, Axios reports .

PALANTIR MONEY: Denver-based data analytics giant Palantir is shifting profits from its European operations to the U.S., reducing its tax bill in Europe, according to a new study. Antoaneta Roussi has

the story .

KYIV LINES UP NEW U.S. ENVOY: Pavlo Palisa, a former army commander once praised by Donald Trump, is in the running to be Ukraine's next ambassador in Washington, replacing Olga Stefanishyna, a Ukrainian official told Veronika Melkozerova.

ROME DIVIDED: Military aid to Ukraine is a hot topic for both the Italian left and right ahead of next year's election, Jacopo Barigazzi writes.

COUPLE BEHIND THE BAN: POLITICO's Mizy Clifton explains how a husband-and-wife team caught then-Prime Minister Keir Starmer's attention on banning social media for kids .

SOCIALISTS' CHINA STANCE

SMART, NOT SOFT: MEP Javi López has defended the Socialists and Democrats from accusations the group is too soft on Beijing. "It's not about being harder or softer, it's about how to be smarter in defense of European interests," the Spanish S&D lawmaker and European Parliament vice president told Zoya Sheftalovich.

Trip recap: López spoke to Playbook after joining an eight-member Foreign Affairs Committee delegation to China last month, during which MEPs met Foreign Minister Wang Yi and other senior officials. The talks were frank, López said. "We think the only way ... is with dialogue, through negotiations, to respect each other, and not a confrontational approach that doesn't serve the European interest."

Sino-Russian ties: The delegation raised China's role in the war on Ukraine, dual-use goods reaching Russia and the need for Beijing to use its influence on the Kremlin to help secure peace. Chinese officials told the MEPs that Beijing wasn't a party to the war, didn't sell weapons to Russia, supported dialogue and believed Europe should be involved in negotiations.

Report still TBC: Playbook reported a couple of weeks ago that the S&D was pushing to soften a critical Parliament report on China, including by dropping a description of Beijing as a "strategic rival." Critics accused the group of caving in to a threat from Beijing of "consequences" if the report passed unchanged — a warning the S&D said it wasn't aware of.

"Values-based realism": Europe should cooperate with China where interests align and compete where they don't, López said. The EU must be "principled but pragmatic, without being naïve," he added, describing the S&D approach as "values-based realism."

About that report: It's still being hashed out, López said, adding he had no further information on the roughly nine-month delay, beyond that talks with the lead MEP on the file remained constructive.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked listeners to send in their favorite geographical indications. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mostly clear skies. High of 26C.

IT'S WHO YOU KNOW: Want free tickets to a concert or football game in Brussels? According to Le Soir , your best bet may be your local Brussels municipal councilor, with the newspaper claiming to have blown the lid off the "opaque system" in which Brussels politicians hand out freebies to cultural and sporting events.

DOUGH-RE-MI: A pizzeria in Saint Gilles went viral after the owner posted a catchy jingle about his business, Pizza Nizar, which exploded on TikTok and has drawn visitors from as far as Paris and Marseille, Sudinfo reports . Even Belgian mail operator Bpost got in on the trend .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

London: Opposition parties are scrambling for Westminster's attention while Andy Burnham takes a holiday.

Paris: PM Sébastien Lecornu has been trumpeting his record on X , fueling speculation that he could run for president.

Washington PM: Donald Trump's former personal lawyer Todd Blanche appears set to become the next attorney general .

AGENDA

— Eurostat publishes June industrial producer prices for the euro area and the EU.

— The German government holds its regular press conference in Berlin at 11:30 a.m. No Cabinet meeting is scheduled.

BIRTHDAYS

Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis; French far-right leader Marine Le Pen; Nuno Brito, Portuguese ambassador to the U.K.; and Euractiv's Nicoletta Ionta.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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